through buybacks and dividends, a program Cook started in 2012 that Jobs never wanted to run. None of that reads like a redemption because there was never a fall to redeem.

The machine underneath

The part of Cook's record that actually deserves the game changer label isn't the stock chart, it's Services. When Cook took over, Apple was a hardware company that happened to sell some software around the edges. By the time he left, Services, the App Store, Apple Music, Apple Pay, iCloud, generated more than $100 billion a year on margins that made the iPhone business look thin by comparison, and that recurring revenue is the reason Apple's valuation held up even in years when iPhone unit sales plateaued. The App Store alone grew from 500 apps in 2008 to roughly 1.8 million, and Cook defended its 15 to 30 percent commission structure through a public antitrust trial against Epic Games in 2021 as fiercely as Jobs would have defended a product decision, arguing the fees paid for a security and distribution layer Apple had spent over $100 billion building. Whether you buy that argument or think the walled garden is a toll booth dressed up as infrastructure, Cook built something that regulators in the US, the EU, and half a dozen jurisdictions have spent years trying to legislate their way around, which is a kind of proof that it worked.

Then there's Apple Silicon, the decision that most cleanly matches what this series is usually about. When Apple announced at WWDC 2020 that it was dropping Intel chips for its own processors, the reaction ranged from dismissive to confused, Apple had switched architectures twice before and this felt like a third instance of muscle memory rather than a real gamble. The M1 chip, shipped that November, ended the debate in one product cycle. Benchmark numbers beat everything Intel or AMD had on the market, battery life stretched past anything a laptop had managed before, and the MacBook Air, a machine that had spent years being merely fine, became the best-reviewed laptop on the planet almost overnight. The real shift was that vertical integration, designing the chip, the software, and the machine as one connected decision, stopped being an Apple-only eccentricity and became the standard the rest of the PC industry had to answer. Qualcomm accelerated its PC silicon push, Microsoft leaned harder into ARM for Windows, and Intel scrambled to redesign its efficiency architecture, all within a few cycles of Apple showing what it had built.



The parts that didn't scale

Cook's tenure wasn't a straight line up, and the honest version of this piece has to sit with the parts that didn't work. Project Titan, Apple's decade-long, multi-billion-dollar attempt to build a car, was quietly killed in 2024 without a single unit shipped. The Vision Pro, launched in 2024 as Apple's first genuinely new product category since the Watch, sold in numbers modest enough that most industry watchers stopped covering it as a mainstream bet within a year. And the sharpest criticism of Cook's final years has nothing to do with hardware at all. Apple Intelligence arrived late, Siri's promised overhaul kept slipping, and for the first time in over a decade, Apple looked like a company reacting to an industry cycle, generative AI, rather than setting one. Cook's operational instincts, patience, supply chain, playing the long game, are exactly the instincts that made Apple's slower AI rollout look like caution in an industry currently rewarding speed above all else. His reliance on Chinese manufacturing, once his efficiency, became his most exposed flank as tariff policy and geopolitics turned his supply chain into a liability rather than an edge.

The handoff

Cook's exit was as understated as his tenure. In an April 2026 announcement, Apple's board confirmed he would step down as CEO, moving into the role of executive chairman, staying involved with policy engagement and strategic matters without running daily operations. In his memo to employees on his final day, Cook wrote that he wasn't leaving Apple, only stepping away from a role he'd loved deeply, language that fits a fifteen-year run built entirely on continuity. John Ternus, a two-decade Apple veteran who led hardware engineering through the M-series transition, the Watch, and the AirPods line, inherits a company at its highest valuation ever and its shakiest position on the one shift Cook's Apple visibly didn't lead.

The unfinished verdict

Cook never got a villain arc because he never took that kind of a risk. He didn't rebuild the company, and he didn't get caught doing something that could turn into a morality play. What he did was compound, for fifteen years, on a bet of operational precision, vertical integration, and a walled ecosystem, and the balance sheet says he won that bet. The question Ternus inherits isn't whether Cook's Apple worked. It's whether the exact discipline that built a $4 trillion company is the same discipline that can survive being outpaced by an industry that, for the first time in Cook's tenure, isn't waiting for Cupertino to move first.